

"How long do you think it'll take me to get down that far?" I asked.

"From the looks of you—about ten days!" the old-timer answered with a broad grin. "That's why I'd rather work for you than for that cream-puff outfit over there . . .!"

He got the job, and stayed on my payroll for many years.

As a footnote to the story, I might add that my well was drilled in record time and proved a good producer. The "last word" in drilling rigs brought in a dry hole and was finally abandoned.

Another good example of what close teamwork and mutual confidence between boss and crew could accomplish can be found in the story of how my men and I licked the

"insoluble" problem of a certain oil lease.

The lease was on a tiny piece of property in the midst of a forest of oil wells in the rich Seal Beach, California, field.

By some fluke, the lease had been overlooked by the firms which were operating there. A company in which I held a substantial interest acquired the lease, but was about to write it off as a dead loss. Everyone agreed that nothing could ever be done with the property. In the first place, it was a plot barely larger than the floor area of a small house. In the second, the only right-of-way providing access

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to a road was over a strip of ground several hundred feet long but less than four feet wide. It was impossible to get supplies and equipment to the property by truck over this constricted path. Even if it had been possible, the postage-stamp-sized plot would not have accommodated a regular-sized derrick and drilling rig. The companies holding leases on adjacent properties refused to grant any right-of-way over their sites, for if a producing well was brought in, it might diminish the production of their own wells, since it would be pumping oil from the same pool.